

Behind the Count: How Transparency in Election Audits Can Influence Voter Confidence

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Abstract

Post-election audits verify vote counts to ensure election legitimacy, yet states vary widely in both the scope of their audits and whether results are disclosed to voters. How does the design of post-election audits shape voter confidence? Drawing on the government transparency literature, I argue that the combination of audit scope and public disclosure is most likely to increase confidence, and that audit information provides the strongest reassurance when both dimensions are at their highest levels. I test this with a pre-registered national survey experiment ($n = 2,030$) in which respondents are randomly assigned to one of nine treatment conditions that vary the percentage of ballots audited (1%, 25%, 100%) and the disclosure of results (not released, released to officials only, released publicly). Relative to the baseline of minimal scope with no disclosure, only the combination of 100% audit scope and full public release significantly increases voter confidence (by 0.51 points on a 0–10 scale), while moderate scope without disclosure significantly decreases it relative to that same baseline. These findings suggest that the design of post-election audits determines whether they achieve their intended goal of building public confidence.

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Introduction

Voter confidence is a central indicator of democratic health in the United States. Voter confidence is a distinct and important measure of how citizens evaluate the electoral process, separate from broader political trust or efficacy ([Atkeson, Alvarez, and Hall, 2015](#); [Claassen et al., 2013](#)). Low confidence, in contrast, can foster disengagement and encourage the rejection of legitimate results ([Grant, Collins, and Gibson, 2021](#); [Higashijima, Kadoya, and Yanai, 2024](#)). While overall voter confidence remains high, with 96% of voters in the 2024 Survey of the Performance of American Elections reporting that they were very or somewhat confident their vote was counted as cast ([Stewart III, 2025](#)), confidence has come under recurring pressure from elite allegations of voter fraud. As early as the 2016 campaign, President Donald Trump claimed the election was “rigged” against him ([Sinclair, Smith, and Tucker, 2018](#)). Weeks before the 2018 midterms, he warned on Twitter of “ILLEGAL VOTING” and directed law enforcement to be on alert ([Axelrod, 2022](#)). After losing the 2020 presidential election, he again alleged widespread fraud, raising doubts about mail ballots, voter identification, deceased voters, and voting machines purportedly linked to foreign interference ([Berlinski et al., 2023](#); [Carter et al., 2024](#)). Both experimental and observational research shows that exposure to elite fraud allegations reduces voter confidence among co-partisans, even when individuals themselves experience no issues at the polling place ([Berlinski et al., 2023](#); [Carter et al., 2024](#)).

Given these pressures, a key question for election administration is what tools are available to maintain or rebuild voter confidence. Election officials already communicate with voters in a variety of ways, from voter education programs ([Suttman-Lea and Merivaki, 2023](#)) to the publication of election results. One tool that has received increasing attention but remains understudied is the post-election audit, a process for verifying the accuracy of the vote count. All 50 states now require some form of post-election audit ([Belant, 2026](#)), yet states vary widely in both the scope of their audits and whether the results are made available to voters

([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#); [Barrett and Atkeson, 2026](#)). Despite their intended role in promoting electoral integrity, we know little about whether and how the design of post-election audits shapes voter confidence.

A small but growing body of research has begun to address this gap. Recent experimental work shows that the format of audit communication matters: interactive dashboards and visual summaries increase voter confidence more than standard audit reports ([Boudreau et al., 2025](#); [Atkeson et al., 2026](#)). However, these studies focus on how audit information is presented, not on what is being communicated. An open question is whether the substance of the audit, specifically how many ballots were checked and whether the results were disclosed to voters, shapes confidence.

This study addresses that question with a pre-registered national survey experiment in which respondents are randomly assigned to one of nine treatment conditions that vary both the percentage of ballots audited (1%, 25%, or 100%) and the disclosure of audit results (not released, released to election officials only, or fully released to the public). I find that only the combination of comprehensive audit scope and full public release significantly increases voter confidence relative to the baseline of a 1% audit with results not released, while moderate audit scope without disclosure actually decreases it. These findings demonstrate that the combination of scope and transparency drives the largest gains in voter confidence, and that audit design determines whether audits achieve their intended goal of building public confidence. The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows: I first review the literature on voter confidence and post-election audits, then describe the institutional variation in audit practices across states, develop a theoretical framework drawing on the government transparency literature, present the experimental design and results, and conclude with implications for election administration and future research.

Theory & Hypotheses

Voter Confidence in Elections

Voter confidence refers to citizens' beliefs about whether their votes were accurately recorded and counted. As [Atkeson, Alvarez, and Hall \(2015\)](#) argue, confidence is conceptually distinct from broader political trust: while trust captures general orientations toward government institutions, voter confidence is specific to the electoral process and can be measured at multiple levels of administration, from the individual ballot to the county, state, and nation.

Voting is a fundamental part of the American system of government, the mechanism through which individuals select candidates and policies that represent their preferences. Democracy relies on citizens' ability to participate meaningfully in elections and to trust that the process accurately records their choices. Over time, the voting process has become increasingly technologically advanced, with states using a mix of optical scan systems, direct-recording electronic machines, and ballot-marking devices ([MIT Election Data and Science Lab, 2023](#)). Despite these advances, there is significant variation in how elections are administered across states. Voters can cast ballots in person on Election Day, during early voting, or by mail. Accurate vote counting is essential because voters must have faith that the process is fair and that the leaders who take office earned their positions legitimately. At the same time, heightened partisan attention to election administration has made voter confidence a critical measure of the health of American democracy. Research shows that voter confidence is shaped by citizens' direct experiences with the electoral process and is distinct from broader measures of political trust ([Atkeson, Alvarez, and Hall, 2015](#); [Claassen et al., 2013](#)). Conversely, low voter confidence is associated with distrust, disengagement, and backlash toward electoral processes ([Berlinski et al., 2023](#); [Carter et al., 2024](#); [Grant, Collins, and Gibson, 2021](#); [Higashijima, Kadoya, and Yanai, 2024](#)).

Voter confidence rose to prominence as a research topic after the 2000 presidential

election, one of the closest in history, which prompted extensive scholarly attention to how voters form confidence judgments and how election administration affects them (Atkeson, Alvarez, and Hall, 2015; Alvarez, Cao, and Li, 2021; Sinclair, Smith, and Tucker, 2018). The controversies surrounding the 2000 election prompted significant policy changes, including the *Help America Vote Act of 2002* and the Carter-Baker Commission’s *Building Confidence in U.S. Elections* report, both of which sought to strengthen public confidence in elections (Alvarez, Cao, and Li, 2021; Claassen et al., 2013; Commission on Federal Election Reform, 2005). Some research suggests a positive association between voter confidence and political participation, though this relationship is complicated by the many factors that shape turnout; many non-voters are not necessarily low in confidence but rather disengaged or ambivalent about elections (Atkeson, Alvarez, and Hall, 2015).

A wide range of factors shape voter confidence. Personal experiences at the polls, such as interactions with unhelpful poll workers or encountering ballot problems, are associated with lower voter confidence (Claassen et al., 2013). Vote choice also affects voter confidence, particularly through the winner-loser effect. Craig et al. (2006) and Sinclair, Smith, and Tucker (2018) find that individuals who voted for the winning candidate report higher confidence after the election. Hood and McKee (2024) illustrate these dynamics in Georgia, showing that while the winner-loser effect was the primary driver of asymmetric changes in voter confidence from 2020 to 2022, the passage of SB 202 also boosted Republican confidence in Georgia’s election system, though it did not have the same effect on Democrats. While the winner-loser effect is one of the most robust findings in the voter confidence literature, it operates alongside other factors, including personal voting experiences, information environments, and institutional practices that also shape confidence levels. Information environments, including media coverage, elite rhetoric, misinformation, and voter education efforts, are also associated with differences in voter confidence (Berlinski et al., 2023; Grant, Collins, and Gibson, 2021; Suttman-Lea and Merivaki, 2023). Finally, institutional practices such as post-election audits or transparency initiatives may increase confidence by demonstrating

integrity (Jaffe et al., 2024).

While voters generally express high trust in local election officials, they report lower confidence in state and national processes, where they have less direct experience and partisan narratives loom larger (Bergeron-Boutin, 2023; Jaffe et al., 2024; Suttman-Lea and Merivaki, 2023). These different findings suggest that proximity, familiarity, and visibility underpin confidence. Voters trust what they can observe. Given this pattern, one institutional practice that may help bridge this gap is post-election auditing, which can provide voters with concrete evidence about how their votes were verified. However, the literature on whether and how audits actually affect voter confidence remains limited, a gap I address in the next section.

Post-Election Audits and Voter Confidence

Although post-election audits are designed to promote transparency and verify the accuracy of election results (Alvarez et al., 2024; Norden et al., 2007), relatively few studies have directly examined their influence on voter confidence. Jaffe et al. (2024) provide one of the first direct tests, using a conjoint experiment to examine how structural features of post-election audits shape voter confidence. They find that how audit results are communicated to the public and the share of ballots audited are more consequential to voter evaluations than the number of errors an audit reveals, suggesting that transparency in audit design matters more than audit findings. Baltz et al. (2025) demonstrate that audits of the 2020 election confirmed the accuracy of the vote count across jurisdictions, but also document that audit results are reported inconsistently and are never compiled in one place, with many states not releasing detailed results publicly. Their findings establish both the substantive foundation for audit-based reassurance and the transparency gap that this study addresses. Alvarez et al. (2024) provide a comprehensive overview of audit methods and identify the need for further research on how audits shape public attitudes, noting that despite their role in verifying election accuracy, audits remain understudied as a tool for building voter

confidence. [Atkeson, McKown-Dawson, and Stein \(2025\)](#) examine a related dimension, finding that the costs of voting, as measured through state laws that increase or decrease ballot access, are linked to voter confidence conditional on partisanship, which suggests that administrative processes more broadly, not just outcomes, shape how voters evaluate the integrity of elections.

More recently, two experimental studies have tested whether exposure to audit information can directly increase voter confidence. [Boudreau et al. \(2025\)](#) conducted a large-scale national survey experiment ($n = 6,013$) in which respondents viewed visual summaries of a Washoe County, Nevada, post-election audit. They found that any version of the audit visual increased confidence in that county's elections by 5 to 6 percentage points. The visual that emphasized the procedural steps of the audit, such as how ballots were randomly selected and hand-counted, outperformed the visual that emphasized the numerical outcomes of the audit, such as the number of discrepancies found. However, these effects did not spill over to confidence in other jurisdictions, and Independents were more responsive than partisans. [Atkeson et al. \(2026\)](#) tested a different dimension of audit communication, comparing an interactive audit dashboard for Leon County, Florida, against standard county audit reports. The dashboard increased confidence in Leon County vote counting by nearly a full point on a 0–10 scale, while standard audit reports produced no significant effect on respondents' own-county confidence. Together, these findings suggest that the format and accessibility of audit information matter as much as exposure itself.

What these studies leave unaddressed is whether the scope of what was audited and whether results are disclosed to voters shape confidence beyond how the information is presented. This question is particularly pressing because scope and disclosure are the two dimensions of audit design that vary most across states and that policymakers can most directly control. Voters may respond differently to learning that 1% of ballots were checked versus 100%, and they may respond differently depending on whether those results were released publicly or kept among election officials. The present study addresses this gap by

experimentally varying both the magnitude of a post-election audit and the transparency of its results.

Post-Election Audits: What They Are and How They Vary

Post-election audits verify the accuracy of election results through an automated or manual recount of some portion of the cast ballots ([Alvarez et al., 2024](#)). [Norden et al. \(2007\)](#) identify several goals of post-election audits: creating an appropriate level of public confidence in election results, deterring fraud, detecting and providing information on errors, providing feedback to improve voting technology, and offering incentives for the electoral system to operate at a higher standard. Despite their intended role in promoting transparency, audits are not well known to voters ([Alvarez et al., 2024](#)), and as [Barrett and Atkeson \(2026\)](#) document, audit results are often not made publicly available even when the law requires it.

Currently, all 50 states require some form of post-election audit ([Belant, 2026](#); [National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). There are three main methods for states to conduct a post-election audit: traditional tabulation, risk-limiting audits, and machine-assisted audits, each following a different scope requirement ([Alvarez et al., 2024](#); [National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). Traditional tabulation audits are the most common type, with 36 states utilizing that method ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). These different types of post-election audits require different amounts of ballots to be verified. For traditional tabulation audits, the percentage of ballots or precincts audited commonly ranges from 1% to 20% ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). For example, California requires as little as 1% of precincts, Pennsylvania requires 2% of votes cast or 2,000 ballots, while states such as Connecticut, Hawaii, and Montana require up to 10% ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). Risk-limiting audits, now required in 7 states, take a different approach by varying the number of ballots examined based on the margin of victory in the election rather than relying on a fixed percentage ([Alvarez et al., 2024](#); [National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). Because risk-limiting audits are

calibrated to the margin of victory, the number of ballots examined can be very small, in some cases even less than 1% of ballots cast. While no state requires a routine 100% audit of all ballots, full verification has occurred in practice through two distinct methods. Georgia conducted a complete hand recount of all presidential ballots in 2020 ([Baltz et al., 2025](#)), while following the 2024 general election in Florida, 53 of the 67 counties that conducted automated audits chose to retabulate 100% of all races and precincts using an independent tabulator, exceeding the state’s 20% statutory minimum ([Barrett and Atkeson, 2026](#)). Both approaches verify 100% of ballots, though they differ in whether the recount is conducted by hand or by machine.

States also vary significantly in who has access to the completed post-election audit results and whether those results are made public ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). Some states, such as Florida, Georgia, Montana, Oregon, and Connecticut, require post-election audits to be conducted publicly and the results to be accessible to voters ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). However, even though some states legally require the results to be publicly available, there are still accessibility issues. For example, in Florida, only 40% of the counties had their post-election audit reports published on their Supervisor of Elections websites despite a legal requirement to make results public ([Barrett and Atkeson, 2026](#)). Other states, such as Pennsylvania and North Carolina, limit the observation of post-election audits to appointed party representatives or candidates, with no public disclosure ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)). Lastly, some states do not even lay out any requirements for post-election audit disclosure to the public ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)).

Given the variation in both the scope and the transparency of post-election audits across states, I selected treatment conditions that reflect this real-world range. For audit magnitude, I selected 1%, 25%, and 100% of ballots audited. The 1% condition captures the low end of what states legally require, representing a minimal level of verification. Even though risk-limiting audits may produce even less than 1%, for simplicity I use this as the minimum,

and it covers many of the fixed-percentage audits currently in practice. The 25% condition serves as a meaningful middle ground between minimal legal compliance and full verification. The 100% condition captures the upper end of the spectrum; while not legally required, full retabulation has occurred multiple times in practice. For audit release, I selected three conditions: “fully released to the public,” reflecting the most transparent practice; “released to election officials only,” reflecting the more common situation where results are shared internally but not communicated to voters; and “not released,” reflecting situations where audit results are not disseminated beyond the audit process itself. Together, these conditions allow the experiment to isolate whether the scope of verification and who learns the results of a post-election audit shape voter confidence.

Theoretical Framework: The Role of Transparency

Given the variation in both the scope and transparency of post-election audits documented above, a key question is how voters process this information when they receive it. Transparency is meaningful only when the people receiving the information have the capacity and interest to process what is being provided to them ([Lindstedt and Naurin, 2010](#); [Schmidhuber, Ingrams, and Hilgers, 2021](#)). Research on government transparency has dealt with similar questions, finding that the relationship between information provision and public trust is far from straightforward ([Crepaz and Arian, 2024](#); [Grimmelikhuijsen, 2012](#); [Porumbescu, Meijer, and Grimmelikhuijsen, 2022](#)). Some scholars have found that transparency can increase trust and reduce the perception of corruption, while others have found that the effects are null or even counterproductive, depending on the type of information released, the audience, and the institutional context in which disclosure occurs ([Alessandro et al., 2021](#); [de Fine Licht, 2014](#)). Building on these insights, I theorize that audit information will shape voter confidence through two distinct mechanisms.

First, the disclosure of election information through post-election audits can act as a signal of legitimacy. The literature identifies two major pathways by which government

transparency affects public attitudes. The first is knowledge-based, where citizens rationally process information and update their beliefs accordingly, and the second is a disclosure-based mechanism in which the very act of making information available signals institutional openness and virtue (Crepaz and Arikan, 2024; Grimmelikhuijsen, 2012). Following the disclosure-based account, transparency works as a heuristic shortcut for individuals, signaling that an organization opening itself up to scrutiny has “nothing to hide” (Crepaz and Arikan, 2024; Worthy, 2010). When organizations demonstrate transparency, citizens tend to respond with greater trust, even without closely examining the substance of what is disclosed (de Fine Licht, 2014; Grimmelikhuijsen, 2012). In the context of post-election audits, the public release of audit results can signal that election administrators are confident enough in the count’s accuracy to invite external evaluation from the public (Baltz et al., 2025), while also reinforcing perceptions of procedural legitimacy (de Fine Licht, 2014; Grimmelikhuijsen and Meijer, 2014). This implies that the public release of audit results should increase voter confidence relative to non-release or internal-only release, independent of what the audit substantively reveals. I therefore expect that the public release of post-election audit results will increase voter confidence relative to an internal-only release or a non-release.

Second, the substance behind the disclosure should matter. Research on government transparency shows that the content of disclosed information shapes how citizens update their evaluations, not just the mere fact of disclosure (Alessandro et al., 2021; Crepaz and Arikan, 2024). Alessandro et al. (2021) show that any information provided increases the perception of transparency, and further demonstrate that when citizens see the government exceeding legal requirements or benchmarks, they report higher levels of trust than citizens who saw under-performers. In the context of post-election audits, the substance is the scope of verification: a comprehensive audit (such as a 100% retabulation) provides a complete check of all ballots, while a 1% audit leaves the vast majority unverified (Baltz et al., 2025). If a comprehensive audit is paired with disclosure to the public, it should activate the knowledge-based mechanism alongside the disclosure signal, allowing citizens

to have concrete evidence to update their confidence levels (Crepaz and Arikan, 2024; Grimmelikhuijsen, 2012). A minimal audit paired with public release still offers some evidence but provides a weaker foundation, which may lead citizens to become skeptical about what the remaining ballots might reveal (Schmidhuber, Ingrams, and Hilgers, 2021; Lindstedt and Naurin, 2010). I therefore expect that voter confidence will increase as the percentage of ballots audited in a post-election audit increases.

Together, both of these mechanisms generate a set of expectations about how post-election audit transparency and audit scope interact. General audit disclosure should provide a positive reassurance effect, showcase institutional openness, and signal procedural legitimacy (Crepaz and Arikan, 2024; de Fine Licht, 2014). The scope of the audit should also matter, with more comprehensive audits providing stronger substantive grounds for confidence (Baltz et al., 2025; Alessandro et al., 2021). Most importantly, the combination of the two should be consequential: the release of post-election audit results should amplify confidence the most when paired with a comprehensive audit that provides both a legitimacy signal and substantive evidence of accuracy (Alessandro et al., 2021; Crepaz and Arikan, 2024). When transparency is high, but the underlying scope of the audit is minimal, the disclosure may produce a weaker or null effect because the openness signal lacks substantive backing (Crepaz and Arikan, 2024; Porumbescu, Meijer, and Grimmelikhuijsen, 2022). The disclosure signal alone is not enough to increase voter confidence; it needs to be paired with meaningful verification of the cast ballots. This leads to the central hypothesis of this study:

H1: Relative to the reference condition of a 1% audit with no public release of results, treatment conditions that combine higher audit scope with public release will produce the largest gains in voter confidence, with the effect of public release being conditional on the magnitude of the audit.¹

¹The pre-registration specifies three hypotheses: one for the independent effect of audit release, one for the independent effect of audit magnitude, and one for their interaction. Because the experimental design presents both dimensions simultaneously to each respondent, the treatment is the combination of scope and release rather than either dimension in isolation. I therefore present

Research Design and Methods

To test this hypothesis, I fielded a pre-registered survey experiment on Prolific in May 2026 with a national sample of U.S. registered voters.² This experiment uses a between-subjects 3×3 factorial design that fully crosses the two treatment dimensions: audit magnitude (1%, 25%, or 100% of ballots audited) and audit release (not released to the public, released to election officials only, or fully released to the public). This experimental design produces nine distinct treatment conditions, and respondents were randomly assigned to one of the nine conditions with equal probability using Qualtrics’s randomization feature. Pre-treatment county-level voter confidence was measured before respondents saw the vignette, creating a quasi pre-post design that improves precision by accounting for respondents’ baseline confidence levels (Clifford, Sheagley, and Piston, 2021).³

Experimental Vignette

Each respondent read a short vignette that described a post-election audit conducted in their county following a recent election. This vignette was designed to resemble the kind of educational material a voter might encounter through official communication from their election administrators. Both treatment dimensions, audit scope and audit release, were piped into the otherwise identical text. This allowed the vignette to be held constant

the combination as the primary hypothesis here, with the directional expectations for release and magnitude treated as theoretical expectations that motivate the design. All pre-registered analyses are reported in full.

²The pre-registration is available at <https://aspredicted.org/qc78is.pdf>.

³Clifford, Sheagley, and Piston (2021) show that repeated measures designs in survey experiments can increase precision without altering treatment effects, provided that additional questions are placed between the pre-treatment measure and the treatment itself to reduce consistency pressures. Jeong et al. (2026) further demonstrate that survey item placement has little effect on data quality or treatment effect estimates, suggesting that the positioning of the pre-treatment measure is unlikely to bias the results.

aside from the two treatment dimensions between respondents. For all respondents, the post-election audit confirmed the original election outcome, and the results of the election did not change. This design choice isolates the effects of the treatment conditions from any confounding effects of the audit revealing errors or altering the outcome. The estimated treatment effects, therefore, apply specifically to the case of a successful audit. The vignette text is presented below, with the manipulated elements in brackets:

Following a recent election, election officials in your county conducted a post-election audit to verify the accuracy of the vote count. The audit examined [*1% / 25% / 100%*] of all ballots cast. The results of the audit were [*not released to the public / released to election officials only / fully released to the public*]. The audit confirmed the election outcome, and the results did not change.

Outcome Variables

The primary outcome variable is post-treatment county-level voter confidence, measured on a 0–10 scale, asking how confident the respondent is that votes in their county were counted correctly in the 2024 General Election. This measure follows the standard approach in the voter confidence literature, where confidence is assessed by asking respondents how confident they are that their ballot was counted as cast, with the measure expanded across levels of electoral administration: county, state, and national ([Atkeson, Alvarez, and Hall, 2015](#)). I chose county-level voter confidence as the primary outcome because it matches the level at which the vignette is framed, with respondents being told the audit occurred in their county. In addition to the primary outcome, I collect secondary outcome variables using the same 0–10 scale with parallel wording for state-level, national-level, and personal-level voter confidence. These secondary outcomes allow for an exploratory analysis of whether audit information given at the county level spills over to affect confidence beyond the county. Pre-treatment county-level voter confidence is included as a control variable to improve the

precision of estimated treatment effects.

Data Collection

Respondents were recruited through Prolific. The sample consists of U.S. registered voters drawn from a national pool. Data collection took place in May 2026. A total of 2,444 respondents began the survey. Respondents were excluded from the analysis if they met any of the following pre-registered criteria: failure to pass the instructional manipulation check, failure to complete all four post-treatment confidence measures, or completion of the survey in under 45 seconds. No outlier exclusion was applied to the dependent variables. Of the 2,444 respondents who began the survey, 414 were excluded for failing one or more of these criteria, yielding a final analytic sample of 2,030 respondents. While the pre-registered target was 2,950, data collection was concluded early due to funding constraints. The final sample of 2,030 respondents (approximately 225 per cell) still provides sufficient statistical power to detect the pre-registered effect sizes of interest.

Estimation Strategy

To estimate the effects of the treatment conditions on voter confidence, I estimate the following OLS regression model:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \gamma \text{PreConf}_i + \sum_{k=2}^9 \beta_k T_{ki} + \epsilon_i \quad (1)$$

where Y_i is respondent i 's post-treatment county-level voter confidence (0–10), PreConf_i is the respondent's pre-treatment county-level voter confidence, T_{ki} is a set of eight indicator variables for each treatment condition (with the 1% audited, not released condition as the omitted reference category), and ϵ_i is the error term.

This specification estimates the effect of each treatment condition relative to the baseline of minimal audit scope with no public disclosure, which represents the weakest level of

both audit substance and transparency. H1 is evaluated by examining whether treatment conditions that combine higher audit scope with public release produce the largest gains in confidence relative to this baseline, and whether the effect of release varies across levels of audit scope. All tests are two-sided with a significance threshold of $p < 0.05$.

In addition to the primary analysis, I conduct several pre-registered exploratory analyses. These include heterogeneous treatment effects by 2024 vote choice and party identification, spillover effects at the state-level, national-level, and personal ballot confidence, as well as treatment effects on a binary item asking whether respondents feel their county audited enough ballots. Results from these exploratory analyses are reported in the appendix.

Results

I present the results of the survey experiment in two parts. I first provide a descriptive overview of county-level voter confidence across the nine treatment conditions, then present the treatment cell regression results and pairwise comparisons that test H1. Full regression results are presented in Table 1.

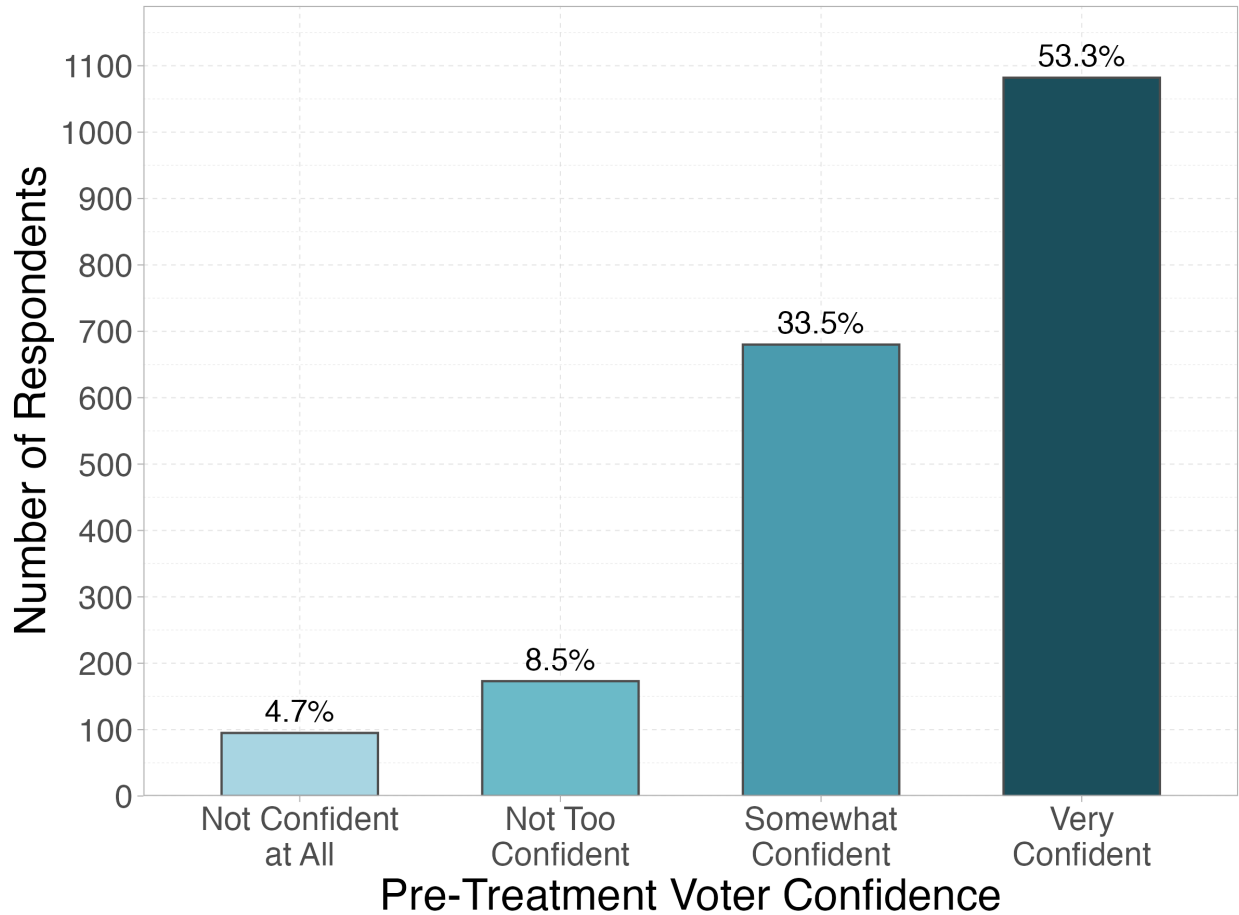
Descriptive Overview

Figure 2 presents the mean county-level voter confidence across each of the nine treatment conditions. Across all 2,030 respondents, the average level of county voter confidence was 7.81 on a 0–10 scale ($SD = 2.51$), indicating that respondents were generally confident that votes in their county were counted correctly.

Pre-treatment confidence was measured on a 4-point scale before respondents saw the vignette. As Figure 1 shows, the majority of respondents entered the experiment already confident: 53.3% reported being “very confident” and 33.5% reported being “somewhat confident” that their ballot was counted correctly, while 8.5% reported being “not too confident” and 4.7% reported being “not confident at all.” This high baseline confidence

is consistent with the broader literature showing that voters tend to express high confidence in their own local elections (Bergeron-Boutin, 2023). Pre-treatment confidence was similar across the nine treatment cells (cell means ranged from 3.21 to 3.42 on the 1–4 scale, with no statistically significant differences across conditions; see Table A8), confirming that randomization successfully balanced baseline confidence across conditions.

Figure 1: Distribution of Pre-Treatment Voter Confidence

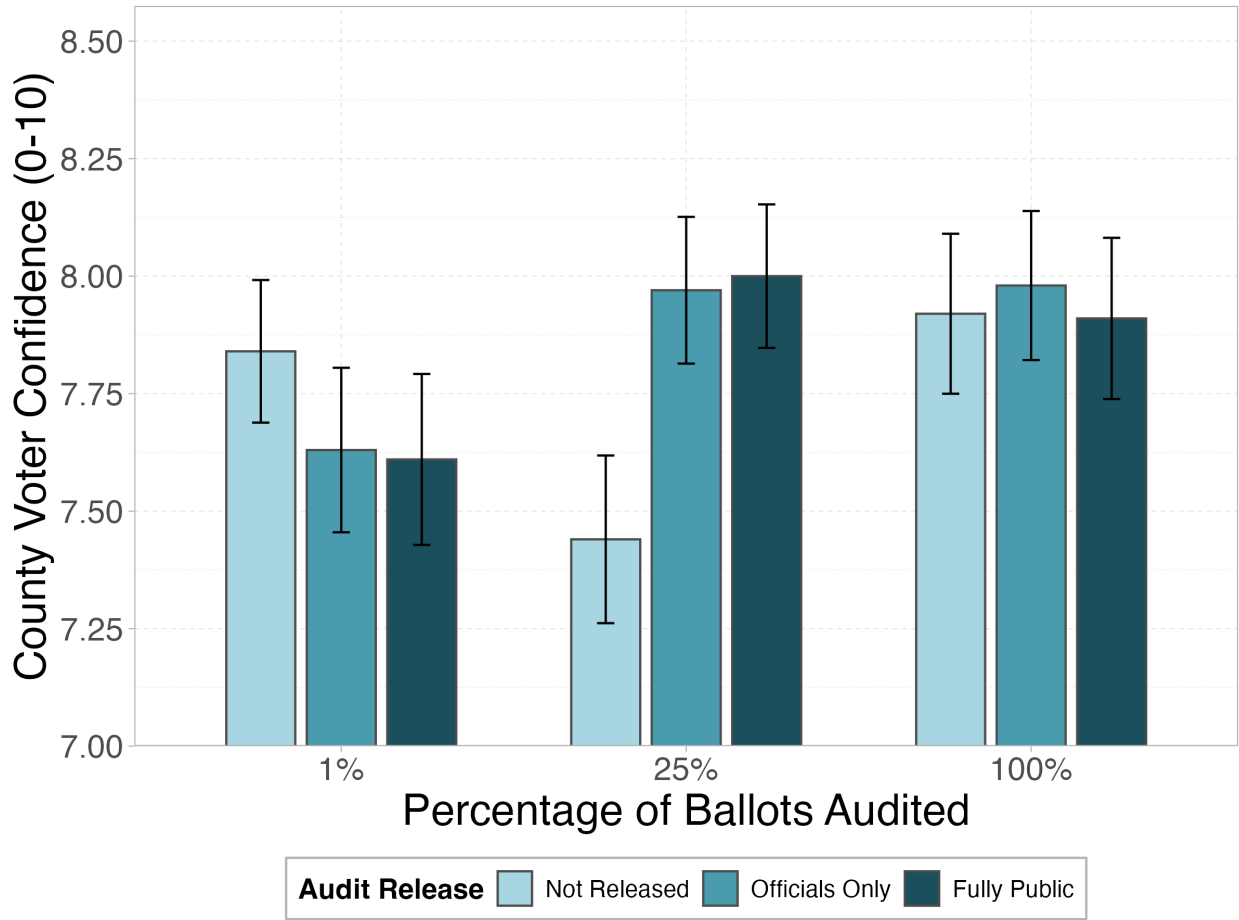


Note: Bars represent the number of respondents at each level of pre-treatment confidence, measured before exposure to the treatment vignette. Percentages are shown above each bar. N = 2,030.

Predicted cell means from the treatment model ranged from a low of 7.39 (25% audited, not released) to a high of 8.24 (100% audited, fully public), a difference of 0.85 points. Cell sizes were similar across conditions, ranging from 219 to 232 respondents per cell, and

covariate balance tests confirmed that baseline characteristics were comparable across all nine treatment cells (see Table A8). Several patterns are visible in Figure 2. At the 1% audit level, confidence is relatively stable across all three release conditions (7.65 to 7.73, no pairwise differences significant). At the 25% level, there is a notable gap: confidence drops to its lowest point in the not released condition (7.39) but rises when results are shared with officials (7.82) or released publicly (7.89). At the 100% level, confidence is consistently high across all release conditions (7.90 to 8.24), with the fully public condition significantly higher than the officials-only condition ($p = 0.039$). These descriptive patterns suggest that the effect of audit release depends on the scope of the audit, consistent with H1.

Figure 2: Mean County-Level Voter Confidence by Audit Scope and Release Condition



Note: Bars represent mean county-level voter confidence (0–10 scale) across nine experimental conditions. Error bars represent standard errors. Y-axis begins at 7.0 to make differences between conditions visible.

Treatment Effects

Table 1 presents the results of the OLS regression estimating the effect of each treatment condition on county-level voter confidence relative to the reference condition of 1% audited with results not released. Pre-treatment confidence is a strong predictor of post-treatment confidence ($\beta = 2.19$, $p < 0.001$), and the model explains approximately 52% of the variance in the outcome. Figure 3 presents these treatment effects visually.

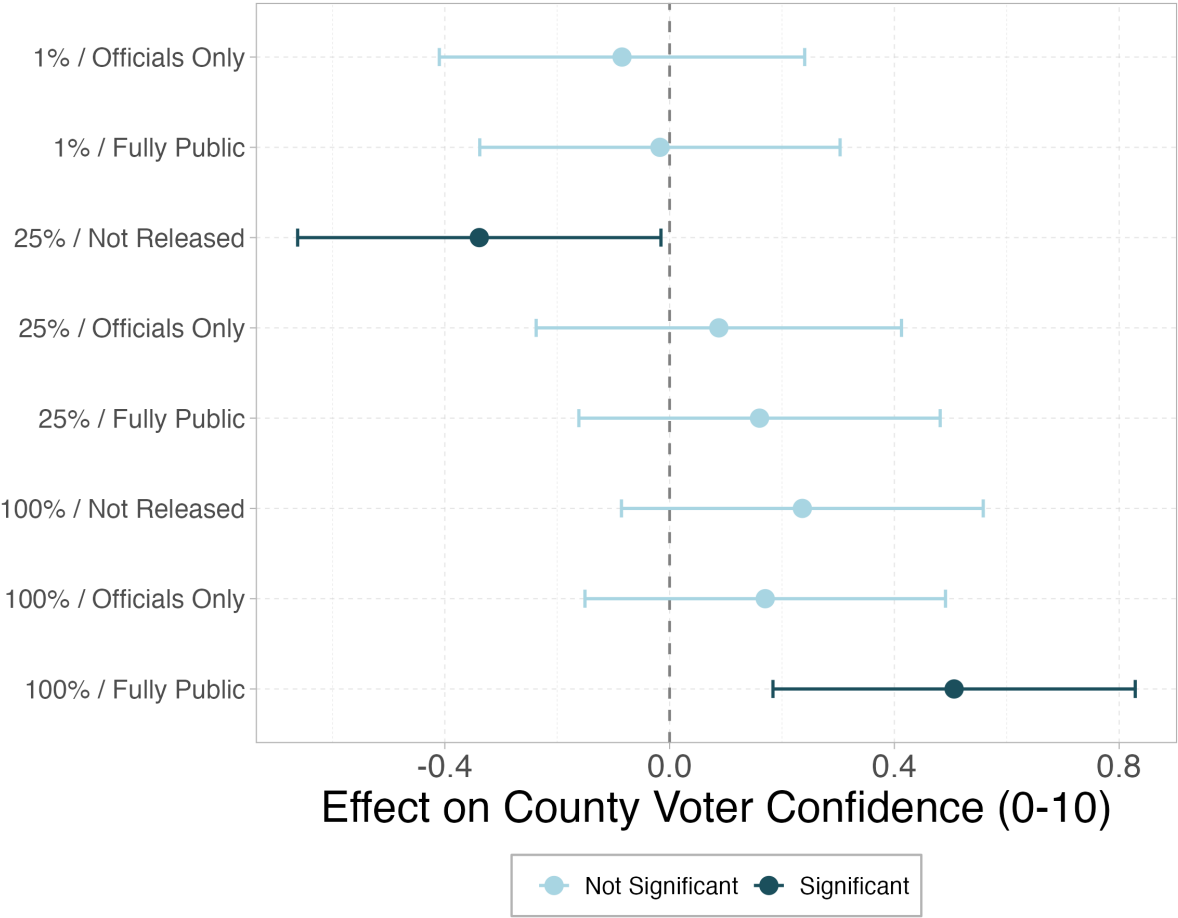
Of the eight treatment conditions, two are significantly different from the reference. The 100% audited, fully released to the public condition produces the largest and most significant gain in voter confidence, increasing it by 0.51 points on the 0–10 scale relative to the baseline ($p = 0.002$). This is the only treatment condition in which both audit scope and transparency are at their highest levels, and it is the only condition that produces a significant positive shift in confidence. This result is consistent with H1: the combination of comprehensive audit scope and full public release produces the largest gains in voter confidence.

The second significant result runs in the opposite direction. The 25% audited, not released condition decreases confidence by 0.34 points relative to the baseline ($p = 0.040$). This is a striking finding: respondents who learned that a moderate share of ballots were audited but that the results were not released reported lower confidence than respondents in the minimal 1%, not released condition. One interpretation is that learning about a 25% audit without any disclosure raises questions rather than providing reassurance. At 1%, respondents may not have enough information to update their confidence in either direction. At 25%, the audit scope is large enough to register as meaningful, but without disclosure, it may signal that something is being withheld. This pattern is consistent with research showing that transparency can decrease trust when the disclosed information raises more questions than it answers ([Bauhr and Grimes, 2014](#); [Worthy, 2010](#)).

No other treatment condition is significantly different from the baseline. The remaining six cells, which represent various combinations of moderate scope with partial transparency or

high scope without full transparency, do not affect confidence in a statistically distinguishable way. The theoretical framework generates an expectation of incremental gains in confidence as audit scope and transparency increase. While the coefficients move broadly in this direction, with predicted confidence generally rising from lower-scope, lower-transparency conditions to higher ones, most of these incremental differences are not statistically significant. The clearest support for H1 comes from the contrast between the two extremes of the treatment space: the significant positive effect of the 100%, fully public condition and the significant negative effect of the 25%, not released condition. Only when both audit scope and transparency are at their highest levels does the treatment produce a significant positive effect on voter confidence.

Figure 3: Coefficient Plot: Treatment Effects on County-Level Voter Confidence



Note: Points represent OLS coefficients relative to the reference category (1% audited, not released), controlling for pre-treatment confidence. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Dark points indicate statistical significance at $p < 0.05$.

Table 1: OLS Regression Results: Treatment Effects on County-Level Voter Confidence

<i>Dependent variable:</i>	
County Voter Confidence (0–10)	
Pre-Treatment Confidence	2.192*** (0.047)
25% / Not Released	−0.339** (0.165)
100% / Not Released	0.236 (0.164)
1% / Officials Only	−0.085 (0.166)
25% / Officials Only	0.088 (0.166)
100% / Officials Only	0.170 (0.164)
1% / Fully Public	−0.017 (0.163)
25% / Fully Public	0.160 (0.164)
100% / Fully Public	0.506*** (0.164)
Constant	0.378* (0.198)
Observations	2,030
R ²	0.523
Adjusted R ²	0.520
F Statistic	245.673*** (df = 9; 2020)

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Reference category: 1% audited, not released to the public.

Pairwise Comparisons

To provide a fuller picture of which conditions differ from one another, I conducted all 36 pairwise comparisons across the nine treatment cells using estimated marginal means from the OLS model, which accounts for pre-treatment confidence. Of these, 13 are statistically

significant at $p < 0.05$, presented in Table 2. Two patterns stand out.

First, the 100% audited, fully public cell is significantly higher than six other cells: 1% audited with no release ($p = 0.002$), 1% audited with officials-only release ($p < 0.001$),⁴ 1% audited with full public release ($p = 0.001$), 25% audited with officials-only release ($p = 0.011$), 25% audited with full public release ($p = 0.034$), and 100% audited with officials-only release ($p = 0.039$). This condition stands apart from the rest of the distribution, suggesting that maximum scope combined with full transparency provides a qualitatively different level of reassurance than any other combination.

Second, the 25% audited, not released cell is significantly lower than seven other cells: 1% audited with no release ($p = 0.040$), 100% audited with no release ($p < 0.001$), 25% audited with officials-only release ($p = 0.010$), 100% audited with officials-only release ($p = 0.002$), 1% audited with full public release ($p = 0.048$), 25% audited with full public release ($p = 0.002$), and 100% audited with full public release ($p < 0.001$). This condition is the clear low point across all nine cells, reinforcing the interpretation that moderate audit scope without disclosure may actively undermine confidence.

Together, these pairwise comparisons confirm that the two extremes of the treatment space, maximum scope with full transparency and moderate scope with no transparency, are driving the significant effects. The remaining cells occupy a middle ground that is not meaningfully distinguishable from the baseline or from each other.

⁴The 1% audited, officials-only cell was examined for compositional differences in partisanship, pre-treatment confidence, and vote choice. No notable imbalances were identified. However, within-party means suggest that Republicans in this cell reported lower confidence (7.13) than Republicans in the 1%, not released cell (7.80), a pattern that also appears in the 1%, fully public cell (7.15). This may reflect Republican skepticism toward official channels at low audit scope, though the interaction model is not powered to detect these within-cell party differences.

Table 2: Significant Pairwise Comparisons Across Treatment Cells

Comparison	Difference	Std. Error	p -value	
25% / No Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.845	0.164	< 0.001	***
1% / Officials Only - 100% / Public Release	-0.591	0.164	< 0.001	***
25% / No Release - 100% / No Release	-0.575	0.163	< 0.001	***
1% / Public Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.523	0.162	0.001	**
25% / No Release - 100% / Officials Only	-0.509	0.163	0.002	**
1% / No Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.506	0.164	0.002	**
25% / No Release - 25% / Public Release	-0.499	0.163	0.002	**
25% / No Release - 25% / Officials Only	-0.426	0.165	0.010	**
25% / Officials Only - 100% / Public Release	-0.419	0.165	0.011	*
25% / Public Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.346	0.163	0.033	*
1% / No Release - 25% / No Release	0.339	0.165	0.040	*
100% / Officials Only - 100% / Public Release	-0.336	0.162	0.039	*
25% / No Release - 1% / Public Release	-0.321	0.163	0.048	*

Note: Table includes only comparisons significant at $p < 0.05$ (13 of 36 total). Positive values indicate the first condition has higher confidence than the second. * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$. Full pairwise comparisons available in the appendix.

Summary of Findings

The results of this experiment provide support for H1. Only the treatment condition combining the highest audit scope with full public release produces a significant positive shift in voter confidence relative to the baseline, increasing it by 0.51 points on the 0–10 scale (approximately 0.20 standard deviations). This effect is comparable in magnitude to those found in other experimental studies of audit information: [Boudreau et al. \(2025\)](#) found effects of 5 to 6 percentage points on a binary confidence measure using visual audit summaries, and [Atkeson et al. \(2026\)](#) found a 0.91-point shift using an interactive audit dashboard with actual election data. That a brief text vignette describing audit scope and

release produces effects in the same range as studies using richer, interactive stimuli suggests that the substance and transparency of the audit itself, not just the format of communication, plays a meaningful role in shaping voter confidence.

The 25%, not released condition, which significantly decreased confidence by 0.34 points relative to the baseline, adds an important dimension to these findings. The spread between the lowest and highest treatment cells (0.85 points, approximately 0.34 standard deviations) represents a meaningful range of policy-relevant variation: moving from the worst-performing combination to the best is equivalent to roughly one third of a standard deviation in voter confidence. It is also worth noting that the high baseline level of county confidence in the sample (mean of 7.81) likely compresses the treatment effects toward zero, meaning the true potential of audit design to shape confidence may be larger than what this experiment captures.

Discussion

The results of this survey experiment suggest that the scope and the transparency of post-election audits may jointly shape voter confidence. Only the treatment condition combining 100% audit scope with full public release produced a significant positive shift in confidence relative to the baseline. At the same time, the 25%, not released condition significantly decreased confidence, suggesting that moderate audit information without disclosure can actively undermine trust. These two findings together support H1: the combination of audit scope and transparency drives meaningful changes in voter confidence.

These findings connect directly to the two theoretical mechanisms outlined in the theory section. The disclosure-based mechanism receives support from the pattern at the 100% level: when audit scope is comprehensive, the 100% audited, fully public condition produces the largest gain (0.51 points), while the 100% audited conditions with no release or officials-only release do not significantly differ from the baseline. This suggests that the public release of

results provides an additional boost beyond what comprehensive verification alone achieves, consistent with the idea that transparency signals institutional openness (Crepaz and Arikan, 2024; Worthy, 2021). The knowledge-based mechanism also finds support: across all three release conditions, confidence tends to be higher at the 100% level than at the 1% level, suggesting that voters use the substantive content of audit information to update their evaluations (Alessandro et al., 2021; Grimmelikhuijsen, 2012).

The most striking finding, however, is the 25%, not released condition. This cell produced the lowest confidence of any treatment condition, significantly lower even than the 1%, not released baseline. There are several possible explanations. At 1%, respondents may not have enough substantive information to update their confidence in either direction. At 25%, the audit scope is large enough to register as meaningful, but without disclosure, it may signal that something is being withheld. This pattern is consistent with research showing that transparency can decrease trust when disclosed information raises more questions than it answers (Bauhr and Grimes, 2014; Worthy, 2010). It is worth noting, however, that with nine treatment conditions, the probability of observing at least one significant result by chance is non-trivial, and this finding should be interpreted with caution until replicated.

At the 100% level, the pattern is different but equally informative. Confidence is consistently high across all three release conditions, with the fully public condition reaching the highest point of any cell. One interpretation is that a 100% audit is such a strong signal of verification that the additional transparency provides only incremental reassurance. Research on transparency and government performance has found similar saturation effects: when the substantive information is strong enough on its own, additional framing or disclosure adds little to public evaluations (Alessandro et al., 2021; Grimmelikhuijsen and Meijer, 2014). Another possibility is that some respondents may have found the 100% audit implausible, particularly those in larger counties. While full retabulation audits have occurred in practice (Baltz et al., 2025; Barrett and Atkeson, 2026), voters unfamiliar with these cases may have viewed the condition with skepticism, which could attenuate the estimated effects at that magnitude.

These findings carry several implications for election administration. First, election officials who want to maximize public voter confidence should prioritize the thoroughness of post-election audits. A comprehensive audit provides the strongest foundation for confidence regardless of how results are communicated. Second, when audits are moderate in scope, which is the reality in the majority of states that audit between 1% and 10% of precincts ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2026](#)), transparency becomes critical. Releasing audit results publicly can compensate for the fact that not all ballots were checked by signaling institutional openness and providing voters with concrete evidence of verification. States that currently audit small percentages and do not actively release results are in the weakest position to build voter confidence through their audit processes. This concern is not hypothetical: [Barrett and Atkeson \(2026\)](#) found that only 40% of Florida counties published their audit reports on their Supervisor of Elections websites, despite a legal requirement to make results public. Standardizing the public reporting of audit results across states and counties, whether through state legislation or administrative rule from a secretary of state or equivalent office, would be a low-cost step toward improving voter confidence without requiring changes to the audit process itself.

The results also connect to the broader voter confidence literature. The proximity and visibility argument suggests that voters trust what they can see and observe, which helps explain why local-level confidence tends to be higher than state or national-level confidence ([Atkeson, Alvarez, and Hall, 2015](#); [Bergeron-Boutin, 2023](#); [Suttman-Lea and Merivaki, 2023](#)). Post-election audits paired with public release effectively bring the verification process closer to voters, giving them something concrete to evaluate. The results also speak to the growing body of research on elite rhetoric and voter confidence. Exposure to fraud allegations from political elites reduces voter confidence among co-partisans, even in the absence of direct evidence of problems ([Berlinski et al., 2023](#); [Carter et al., 2024](#)). Post-election audits that are both thorough and publicly released may serve as a counterweight to these allegations by providing concrete, positive information about the accuracy of the vote count. Whether

audits can effectively counteract elite-driven skepticism is an important question for future research.

Limitations

Several limitations of this study should be acknowledged. First, the vignette held constant that the audit confirmed the original election outcome and that the results did not change. In practice, audits occasionally reveal discrepancies that may need to be resolved. It is possible that audit information revealing errors or changes to the vote count would produce different, and potentially negative, effects on voter confidence. Second, the sample was recruited through Prolific and, while diverse, is not perfectly representative of the U.S. population. Prolific respondents tend to be younger, more educated, and more politically engaged than the general public ([Peer et al., 2022](#)), which may limit the generalizability of these findings. Third, the pre-registered target sample size was 2,950, but data collection was concluded at 2,030 due to funding constraints. While the final sample provides sufficient statistical power to detect the effects reported here, a larger sample would have provided greater precision. Fourth, the vignette presents a simplified version of how voters might encounter audit information. In the real world, audit results reach voters through media reports, official communications, and partisan messaging, all of which may frame the information in ways that amplify or diminish its effects on confidence. Fifth, this study measures immediate post-treatment confidence, and it is unknown whether the effects of audit information persist over time or decay quickly once voters are no longer thinking about the audit. Sixth, the high baseline level of county confidence in the sample (mean of 7.81 on a 0–10 scale) likely creates a ceiling effect that compresses the treatment effects toward zero, meaning the true potential of audit design to shape confidence may be larger than what this experiment captures. Seventh, only county-level confidence was tested as the primary outcome. Effects on state-level and national-level confidence remain exploratory, and it is unclear whether the patterns observed at the county level would replicate at higher levels of electoral administration where partisan

narratives may play a larger role.

Future research should build on these findings in several directions. First, researchers should test whether audit results that reveal errors or discrepancies decrease voter confidence or increase it by demonstrating that the system is capable of catching and correcting mistakes. Second, heterogeneous effects by partisanship and vote choice are an important next step, as the existing literature suggests that fraud allegations and confidence are deeply shaped by partisan identity (Berlinski et al., 2023; Carter et al., 2024). Understanding whether audits are more effective for partisans who won or lost the election, or for those with different levels of baseline trust, would add important nuance to these findings. Third, future studies should examine how media framing of audit results shapes voter confidence compared to the direct provision of information used in this experiment. Finally, Boudreau et al. (2025) and Atkeson et al. (2026) have begun to test the effects of actual audit reports and interactive dashboards on voter confidence; future work should continue to examine whether richer audit stimuli produce larger or more durable effects than vignette descriptions.

Concluding Remarks

This study examined how transparency and the scope of post-election audits affect voter confidence using a pre-registered 3×3 factorial survey experiment with 2,030 U.S. registered voters. By varying both the percentage of ballots audited and whether the audit results were publicly released, the experiment provides direct experimental evidence on how these two dimensions of audit design jointly shape voter confidence.

The results reveal that the combination of audit scope and transparency matters. When respondents learned that 100% of ballots were reexamined and the results were fully released to the public, their confidence increased significantly. When respondents learned that 25% of ballots were audited but the results were not released, their confidence decreased. The remaining treatment conditions, representing various partial combinations of scope and

transparency, did not significantly differ from the baseline. These findings demonstrate that audit design, not just audit existence, determines whether post-election audits achieve their intended goal of building public confidence.

Beyond addressing the gap identified by [Alvarez et al. \(2024\)](#) regarding whether and how post-election audits influence voter confidence, the analysis extends the government transparency literature ([Alessandro et al., 2021](#); [Crepaz and Arian, 2024](#); [de Fine Licht, 2014](#)) into the election administration context. The same mechanisms that govern trust in government institutions, both the disclosure signal and the substantive content of disclosed information, apply to how voters evaluate the integrity of the vote count.

As post-election audits continue to expand across the United States, these findings suggest that election administrators and policymakers should attend not only to whether audits are conducted but also to how thorough they are and whether their results reach the voters they are meant to reassure. Audit transparency works, but only when there is substance behind it.

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Supplementary Materials

Part I

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A Survey Experiment

The following presents the survey instrument used in the study. Questions are organized by survey block in the order respondents encountered them. Treatment conditions are shown in brackets. The survey began with a standard informed consent form and ended with a debriefing statement; both are available upon request.

Attention Check

Q1. We would like to get a sense of your consumption of political news. To demonstrate that you've read this much, just go ahead and select both every day and never among the options below, no matter how often you watch political news. Based on the text you read above, how often do you watch political news on TV?

1. Every day
2. Once a week
3. Once a month
4. A few times a year
5. Never

Pre-Treatment Measures

Q2. Did you vote in the 2024 general election in the United States?

1. Yes
2. No

Q3. What state did you vote in for the 2024 general election?

[Dropdown menu: Alabama through Washington D.C.]

Q4. Which presidential candidate did you vote for in the 2024 General Election?

1. Donald Trump
2. Kamala Harris
3. Robert Kennedy Jr.
4. Chase Russell Oliver
5. Jill Stein
6. Other candidate, please specify: _____

Q5. How confident are you that your ballot was counted correctly during the 2024 general election?

1. Very confident
2. Somewhat confident
3. Not too confident
4. Not confident at all

Q6. With which party, if any, were you registered for the 2024 General Election?

1. Democrat
2. Republican
3. No Political Affiliation/Unaffiliated
4. Other party, please specify: _____

Q7. How would you rate the ideology of yourself?

1. Very Liberal
2. Liberal
3. Somewhat Liberal
4. Middle of the road
5. Somewhat Conservative
6. Conservative
7. Very Conservative
8. Not sure

Q8. Generally speaking, do you usually think of yourself as a Democrat, a Republican, an Independent, or what?

1. Democrat
2. Republican
3. Independent
4. Other party, please specify: _____

Q8a. [If Democrat] Would you call yourself a strong Democrat, or a not very strong Democrat?

1. Strong Democrat
2. Not so strong Democrat

Q8b. [If Independent] Do you consider yourself closer to the Republican Party or the Democrat Party?

1. Closer to Republican
2. Closer to Democrat

Q8c. [If Republican] Would you call yourself a strong Republican, or a not very strong Republican?

1. Strong Republican
2. Not so strong Republican

Treatment Vignette

Respondents were randomly assigned to one of nine conditions in a 3×3 factorial design. The treatment text was as follows, with manipulated elements shown in brackets:

Following a recent election, election officials in your county conducted a post-election audit to verify the accuracy of the vote count. The audit examined [*1% / 25% / 100%*] of all ballots cast. The results of the audit were [*not released to the public / released to election officials only / fully released to the public*]. The audit confirmed the election outcome, and the results did not change.

Factual Manipulation Check

Q9. What percentage of ballots were included in the post-election audit?

1. 1%
2. 25%
3. 100%
4. Not sure / Don't remember

Q10. What did the election officials do with the results of the audit?

1. The results were not released
2. Only election officials received the results
3. The results were fully released to the public
4. Not sure / Don't remember

Post-Treatment Outcome Measures

All confidence measures used a slider scale from 0 (no confidence) to 10 (highest confidence).

Q11. Thinking about vote counting throughout **your county**, on a scale of 0 (no confidence) to 10 (highest confidence), how **confident** are you that votes in **your county** were **counted correctly** during the 2024 election?

Q12. Thinking about vote counting throughout **your state**, on a scale of 0 (no confidence) to 10 (highest confidence), how **confident** are you that votes in **your state** were **counted correctly** during the 2024 election?

Q13. Thinking about vote counting in **other states**, on a scale of 0 (no confidence) to 10 (highest confidence), how **confident** are you that votes in **other states** were **counted correctly** during the 2024 election?

Q14. On a scale of 0 (no confidence) to 10 (highest confidence), how **confident** are you that the **results of the election** in **your county** were **reported correctly** during the 2024 election?

Q15. On a scale of 0 (no confidence) to 10 (highest confidence), how **confident** are you that the **voting process** in **your county** was **carried out properly and free from fraud or major problems** during the 2024 election?

Q16. On a scale of 0 (no confidence) to 10 (highest confidence), how **confident** are you that **no ballots were stolen or changed** in **your county** during the 2024 election?

Q17. What share of ballots do you think should be audited after an election?

1. 1–5%
2. 6–10%
3. 11–21%
4. 21–30%
5. 31–40%
6. 41–50%
7. 51–60%
8. 61–70%
9. 71–80%
10. 81–90%
11. 91–100%

Q18. How important is it that audit results be publicly released?

1. Extremely important
2. Very important
3. Moderately important
4. Slightly important
5. Not at all important

Q19. Do you know if your state conducts a post-election audit?

1. Yes
2. No
3. I don't know

Demographics

Q20. What is the highest level of education you have completed?

1. Less than high school
2. High school or equivalent (GED)
3. Some college or university
4. Associate degree
5. Bachelor's degree
6. Master's degree
7. Professional degree (MD, DDS, JD)
8. Doctorate degree

Q21. What is your age? -----

Q22. What racial or ethnic group best describes you?

1. White
2. Black
3. Hispanic
4. Asian
5. Native American

6. Middle Eastern
7. Two or more races
8. Other, please specify: _____

Q22a. [If Two or more races] Please select which racial or ethnic groups best describe you.
[Select all that apply: White, Black, Hispanic, Asian, Native American, Middle Eastern, Other]

Q23. What is your gender?

1. Male
2. Female
3. Non-binary
4. Transgender
5. Other, please specify: _____

A.1 Respondent Demographics

Tables A1–A7 present the demographic characteristics of the analytic sample.

Table A1: Gender

Gender	<i>n</i>	%
Female	1,061	52.3
Male	940	46.3
Non-binary	24	1.2
Transgender	4	0.2
Other	1	0.0

Table A2: Race / Ethnicity

Race / Ethnicity	<i>n</i>	%
White	1,466	72.2
Black	251	12.4
Hispanic	119	5.9
Asian	113	5.6
Two or more races	58	2.9
Native American	7	0.3
Middle Eastern	6	0.3
Other	10	0.5

Table A3: Education

Education	<i>n</i>	%
Less than high school	6	0.3
High school or equivalent (GED)	222	10.9
Some college or university	380	18.7
Associate degree	223	11.0
Bachelor's degree	804	39.6
Master's degree	312	15.4
Professional degree (MD, DDS, JD)	46	2.3
Doctorate degree	37	1.8

Table A4: Party Identification

Party Identification	<i>n</i>	%
Democrat	966	47.6
Independent	493	24.3
Republican	533	26.3
Other	38	1.9

Table A5: 2024 Presidential Vote Choice

Candidate	<i>n</i>	%
Kamala Harris	1,189	58.6
Donald Trump	705	34.7
Robert Kennedy Jr.	21	1.0
Chase Russell Oliver	13	0.6
Jill Stein	24	1.2
Other candidate	78	3.8

Table A6: Ideology

Ideology	<i>n</i>	%
Very Liberal	378	18.6
Liberal	452	22.3
Somewhat Liberal	243	12.0
Middle of the road	333	16.4
Somewhat Conservative	181	8.9
Conservative	304	15.0
Very Conservative	130	6.4
Not sure	9	0.4

Table A7: Age

Mean (SD)	45.8 (14.4)
Range	18–83

A.2 Randomization Check

To confirm that randomization successfully balanced baseline characteristics across treatment conditions, I conducted balance tests for eight covariates. Table A8 presents the results. None of the tests reached statistical significance, confirming that randomization produced comparable groups across all nine treatment conditions.

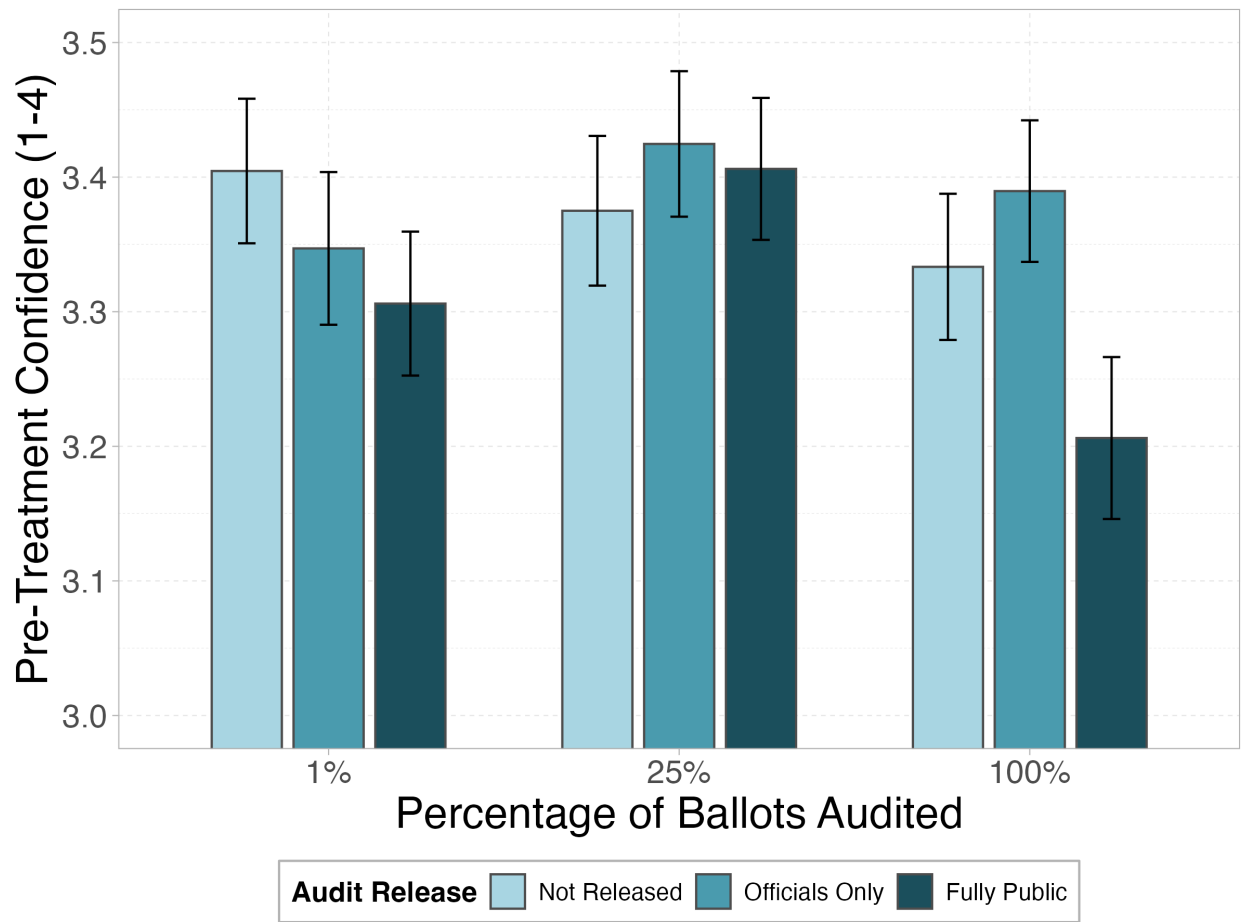
Table A8: Covariate Balance Across Treatment Conditions

Covariate	Test	<i>p</i> -value
Pre-treatment confidence	ANOVA	0.142
Age	ANOVA	0.318
Education	ANOVA	0.692
Gender	χ^2	0.402
Race / Ethnicity	χ^2	0.364
Party identification	χ^2	0.650
Vote choice	χ^2	0.477
Ideology	χ^2	0.851

Note: ANOVA tests compare means across nine treatment cells; χ^2 tests compare distributions across cells. No test reaches statistical significance at $p < 0.05$. $N = 2,030$.

Figure A1 presents pre-treatment confidence by treatment cell, showing similar means (range: 3.21 to 3.42 on the 1–4 scale) and overlapping confidence intervals across all nine conditions.

Figure A1: Pre-Treatment Voter Confidence by Treatment Condition



Note: Bars represent mean pre-treatment confidence (1-4 scale) by treatment cell. Error bars represent standard errors. N = 2,030.

A.3 Manipulation Check Pass Rates

Following the treatment vignette, respondents answered two factual manipulation checks: one asking what percentage of ballots were audited (Q9) and one asking what election officials did with the results (Q10). Respondents who failed either check were retained in the primary analysis; a robustness check excluding these respondents is reported in Section B.1. Among the 2,030 respondents in the final sample, pass rates were high but varied across conditions.

For the audit percentage check, the overall pass rate was 94.6%. Pass rates were similar across the three scope conditions: 96.4% for the 25% condition, 95.8% for the 1% condition, and 91.6% for the 100% condition (Table A9).

Table A9: Manipulation Check Pass Rates: Audit Percentage (Q9)

Condition	<i>N</i>	Correct	Pass Rate (%)
1%	671	643	95.8
25%	672	648	96.4
100%	687	629	91.6
Overall	2,030	1,920	94.6

For the audit release check, the overall pass rate was 81.5%. Pass rates varied more across conditions: 89.4% for the fully released to the public condition, 84.2% for the not released condition, and 70.6% for the released to election officials only condition (Table A10). The lower pass rate for the officials only condition likely reflects the subtlety of the distinction between “not released” and “released to election officials only,” which may have been more difficult for respondents to differentiate than the other two conditions.

Table A10: Manipulation Check Pass Rates: Audit Release (Q10)

Condition	<i>N</i>	Correct	Pass Rate (%)
Not released	672	566	84.2
Officials only	669	472	70.6
Fully public	689	616	89.4
Overall	2,030	1,654	81.5

Table A11 presents pass rates by treatment cell. The percentage of respondents who correctly answered both manipulation checks ranged from 64.5% (100% / officials only) to 90.0% (25% / fully public). The lowest combined pass rates were concentrated in the officials only release conditions, consistent with the pattern described above.

Table A11: Manipulation Check Pass Rates by Treatment Cell

Treatment Cell	<i>N</i>	Pct Check (%)	Release Check (%)	Both (%)
1% / Not Released	220	93.6	86.4	83.2
1% / Officials Only	219	97.3	71.7	70.8
1% / Fully Public	232	96.6	85.3	83.2
25% / Not Released	224	97.3	82.1	81.2
25% / Officials Only	219	96.3	74.4	72.1
25% / Fully Public	229	95.6	92.6	90.0
100% / Not Released	228	89.0	84.2	78.5
100% / Officials Only	231	93.5	65.8	64.5
100% / Fully Public	228	92.1	90.4	85.5

Note: Pass rates reflect the percentage of respondents who correctly identified their assigned treatment condition. “Both” indicates respondents who passed both checks. Respondents who failed these checks were retained in the primary analysis. $N = 2,030$.

B Additional Results

B.1 Robustness: Excluding Respondents Who Failed Manipulation Checks

The primary analysis retains all 2,030 respondents regardless of their performance on the post-treatment manipulation checks, since excluding respondents based on a post-treatment measure can introduce bias by conditioning on a variable that may itself be affected by the treatment (Montgomery, Nyhan, and Torres, 2018). As a robustness check, however, I re-estimate the primary model after excluding respondents who incorrectly identified either their assigned audit percentage or their assigned audit release condition (restricted $n = 1,600$).

The results are substantively unchanged. The 100% / fully public condition remains the largest positive effect, moving from 0.51 ($p = 0.002$) to 0.49 ($p = 0.005$). The 25% / not released condition retains nearly the same magnitude (-0.34 in both samples), though the p -value shifts from 0.040 to 0.061 due to the reduced sample size. This shift reflects the loss of statistical power rather than a change in the underlying effect. One notable change is that the 100% / not released condition, which was not significant in the full sample (0.24, $p = 0.150$), becomes significant in the restricted sample (0.38, $p = 0.032$), suggesting that comprehensive audit scope on its own may boost confidence once the analysis is limited to respondents who fully absorbed the treatment information. The remaining treatment conditions are non-significant in both samples. Overall, these results support the decision to retain the full sample in the primary analysis while confirming that the core findings are not driven by inattentive respondents.

Table A12: Robustness Check: Full Sample vs. Excluding Failed Manipulation Checks

Treatment Cell	Full Sample (N = 2,030)		Restricted (N = 1,600)	
	β	p	β	p
25% / Not Released	-0.339	0.040	-0.334	0.061
100% / Not Released	0.236	0.150	0.384	0.032
1% / Officials Only	-0.085	0.609	-0.004	0.983
25% / Officials Only	0.088	0.597	0.084	0.650
100% / Officials Only	0.170	0.298	0.147	0.432
1% / Fully Public	-0.017	0.916	0.114	0.516
25% / Fully Public	0.160	0.329	0.169	0.329
100% / Fully Public	0.506	0.002	0.488	0.005

Note: Reference category: 1% audited, not released. Both models control for pre-treatment confidence. The restricted sample excludes respondents who incorrectly identified their assigned audit percentage or audit release condition on the post-treatment factual checks.

B.2 Full Pairwise Comparisons

Table A13 presents the complete set of 36 pairwise comparisons across all nine treatment cells. Comparisons are ordered by p -value. Significant comparisons (13 of 36) are marked with asterisks.

Table A13: Full Pairwise Comparisons Across All Treatment Cells

Comparison	Difference	Std. Error	p -value	
25% / No Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.845	0.164	< 0.001	***
1% / Officials Only - 100% / Public Release	-0.591	0.164	< 0.001	***
25% / No Release - 100% / No Release	-0.575	0.163	< 0.001	***
1% / Public Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.523	0.162	0.001	**
25% / No Release - 100% / Officials Only	-0.509	0.163	0.002	**
1% / No Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.506	0.164	0.002	**
25% / No Release - 25% / Public Release	-0.499	0.163	0.002	**
25% / No Release - 25% / Officials Only	-0.426	0.165	0.010	**
25% / Officials Only - 100% / Public Release	-0.419	0.165	0.011	*
25% / Public Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.346	0.163	0.033	*
100% / Officials Only - 100% / Public Release	-0.336	0.162	0.039	*
1% / No Release - 25% / No Release	0.339	0.165	0.040	*
25% / No Release - 1% / Public Release	-0.321	0.163	0.048	*
100% / No Release - 1% / Officials Only	0.321	0.164	0.051	
100% / No Release - 100% / Public Release	-0.270	0.163	0.097	
100% / No Release - 1% / Public Release	0.253	0.162	0.118	
1% / Officials Only - 100% / Officials Only	-0.255	0.164	0.120	
25% / No Release - 1% / Officials Only	-0.254	0.165	0.124	
1% / Officials Only - 25% / Public Release	-0.245	0.164	0.136	
1% / No Release - 100% / No Release	-0.236	0.164	0.150	
100% / Officials Only - 1% / Public Release	0.187	0.161	0.246	
1% / Public Release - 25% / Public Release	-0.177	0.162	0.274	
1% / No Release - 100% / Officials Only	-0.170	0.164	0.298	
1% / Officials Only - 25% / Officials Only	-0.172	0.166	0.299	
1% / No Release - 25% / Public Release	-0.160	0.164	0.329	
100% / No Release - 25% / Officials Only	0.149	0.164	0.366	
25% / Officials Only - 1% / Public Release	0.105	0.164	0.522	
1% / No Release - 25% / Officials Only	-0.088	0.166	0.597	
1% / No Release - 1% / Officials Only	0.085	0.166	0.609	
25% / Officials Only - 100% / Officials Only	-0.083	0.164	0.614	
100% / No Release - 25% / Public Release	0.076	0.162	0.639	
25% / Officials Only - 25% / Public Release	-0.072	0.164	0.659	
1% / Officials Only - 1% / Public Release	-0.067	0.164	0.680	
100% / No Release - 100% / Officials Only	0.066	0.162	0.684	
1% / No Release - 1% / Public Release	0.017	0.163	0.916	
100% / Officials Only - 25% / Public Release	0.010	0.162	0.950	

Note: Positive values indicate the first condition has higher confidence than the second. Comparisons ordered by p -value. * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$. N = 2,030.

B.3 Spillover Effects on Other Confidence Measures

To examine whether treatment effects extend beyond county-level vote counting confidence, I estimated the treatment cell model with five alternative dependent variables. The first set examines geographic spillover: state-level and national-level confidence. The second set examines alternative dimensions of county-level confidence: whether results were reported correctly, whether the process was free from fraud, and whether ballots were stolen or changed. All outcomes use the same 0–10 scale and the same model specification as the primary analysis. Table A14 presents the geographic results and Table A15 presents the county-level alternative measures.

Geographic Spillover

The 100% / fully public condition is the only treatment that produces significant effects on both geographic levels. It increases state-level confidence by 0.52 points ($p < 0.001$) and national-level confidence by 0.47 points ($p = 0.021$). The 25% / fully public condition also reaches significance for national confidence (0.55, $p = 0.007$), suggesting that meaningful scope paired with public release can extend beyond the county even at moderate levels. No other treatment condition significantly affects state or national confidence. This pattern is consistent with the broader voter confidence literature, which finds that confidence is highest at the local level and declines at higher levels of administration where partisan narratives play a larger role (Bergeron-Boutin, 2023; Suttman-Lea and Merivaki, 2023). The vignette described an audit conducted in the respondent’s county, so the limited geographic spillover is not surprising: the treatment information was framed at the county level and appears to have been processed accordingly. These findings are also consistent with Boudreau et al. (2025) and Atkeson et al. (2026), both of which found limited spillover of audit information beyond the jurisdiction in which the audit was conducted.

Table A14: Treatment Effects on State and National Voter Confidence

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>	
	State Confidence	National Confidence
25% / Not Released	-0.196 (0.171)	0.016 (0.203)
100% / Not Released	0.183 (0.170)	0.324 (0.202)
1% / Officials Only	0.038 (0.172)	-0.021 (0.204)
25% / Officials Only	0.118 (0.172)	0.132 (0.204)
100% / Officials Only	0.250 (0.169)	0.549*** (0.202)
1% / Fully Public	-0.040 (0.169)	0.191 (0.202)
25% / Fully Public	0.256 (0.170)	0.234 (0.202)
100% / Fully Public	0.520*** (0.170)	0.468** (0.203)
Pre-Treatment Confidence	2.198*** (0.049)	1.961*** (0.058)
Constant	0.138 (0.205)	-0.054 (0.244)
Observations	2,030	2,030
R ²	0.506	0.366
Adjusted R ²	0.504	0.363
F Statistic (df = 9; 2020)	230.351***	129.573***

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Reference category: 1% audited, not released to the public.

All outcomes measured on 0-10 scale.

Alternative County-Level Confidence Measures

The 100% / fully public condition again produces significant effects across all three alternative county-level measures: reporting accuracy (0.56, $p = 0.002$), free from fraud (0.50, $p = 0.008$), and no stolen ballots (0.64, $p = 0.004$). This consistent pattern reinforces the main finding: the combination of comprehensive audit scope and full public release produces broad reassurance that extends beyond the specific question of whether votes were counted correctly.

The no stolen ballots measure shows the most treatment sensitivity overall. In addition to the 100% / fully public effect, several other conditions reach significance: 100% / not released (0.49, $p = 0.025$), 100% / officials only (0.46, $p = 0.037$), 25% / fully public (0.63, $p = 0.004$), and 1% / fully public (0.49, $p = 0.025$). This suggests that ballot security concerns may be more responsive to audit information than other confidence dimensions, with both scope and transparency independently contributing to reassurance that ballots were not tampered with. The reporting accuracy measure shows a similar but weaker pattern, with 25% / officials only (0.33, $p = 0.059$) and 100% / officials only (0.34, $p = 0.054$) reaching marginal significance. The free from fraud measure is affected only by the 100% / fully public condition.

Overall, these results confirm that the primary finding is not an artifact of the specific county vote-counting question. The combination of comprehensive scope and full transparency produces consistent positive effects across multiple dimensions of electoral confidence, while neither scope nor transparency alone is sufficient to produce broad reassurance across most measures.

Table A15: Treatment Effects on Alternative County-Level Confidence Measures

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Reporting Accuracy	Free from Fraud	No Stolen Ballots
25% / Not Released	−0.083 (0.176)	−0.145 (0.188)	0.056 (0.220)
100% / Not Released	0.260 (0.176)	0.223 (0.188)	0.491** (0.219)
1% / Officials Only	0.090 (0.177)	0.158 (0.189)	0.370* (0.222)
25% / Officials Only	0.334* (0.177)	0.177 (0.189)	0.250 (0.222)
100% / Officials Only	0.199 (0.175)	0.215 (0.187)	0.458** (0.219)
1% / Fully Public	0.012 (0.175)	0.028 (0.187)	0.205 (0.219)
25% / Fully Public	0.337* (0.175)	0.290 (0.187)	0.628*** (0.219)
100% / Fully Public	0.559*** (0.176)	0.498*** (0.188)	0.640*** (0.220)
Pre-Treatment Confidence	2.139*** (0.050)	2.228*** (0.054)	2.307*** (0.063)
Constant	0.390* (0.212)	−0.046 (0.226)	−0.924*** (0.265)
Observations	2,030	2,030	2,030
R ²	0.476	0.463	0.404
Adjusted R ²	0.474	0.461	0.402
F Statistic (df = 9; 2020)	204.282***	193.732***	152.375***

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Reference category: 1% audited, not released to the public.

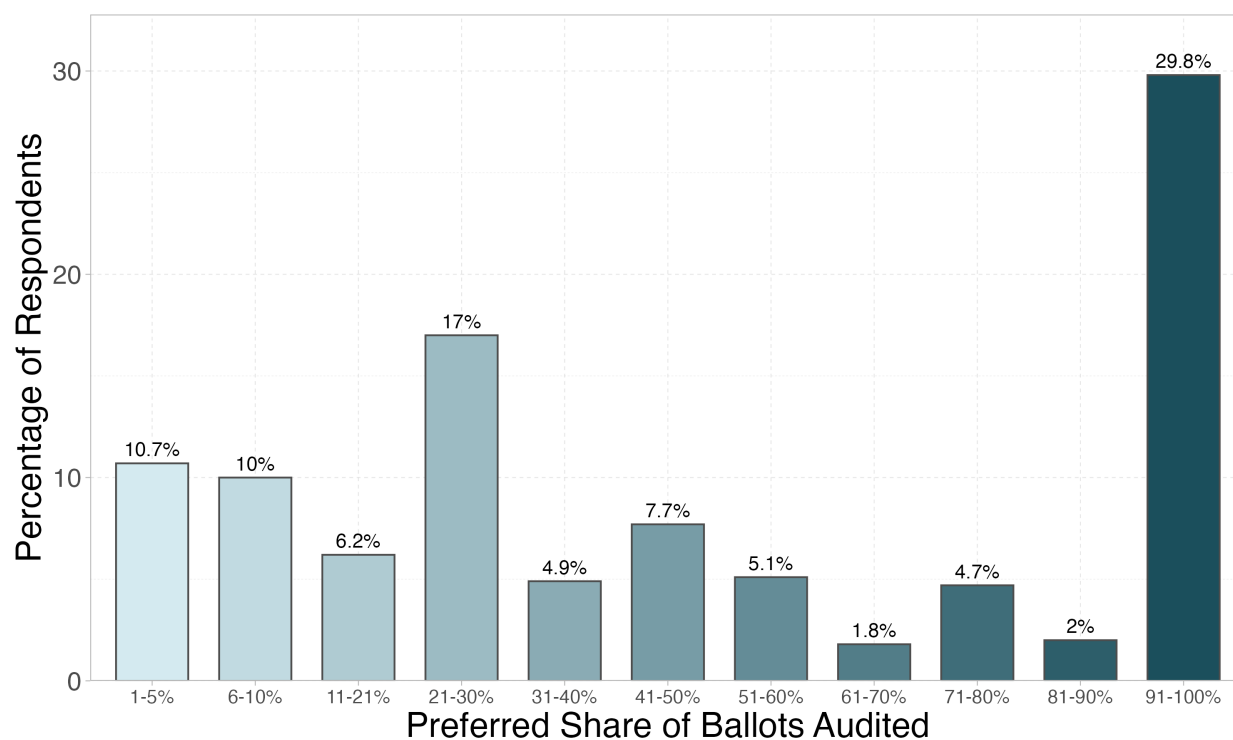
All outcomes measured on 0-10 scale.

C Exploratory Analyses

C.1 Voter Preferences for Audit Scope

After completing the post-treatment confidence measures, respondents were asked what share of ballots they believe should be audited after an election (Q17). Figure A2 presents the results. The most common response was 91–100%, selected by 29.8% of respondents, followed by 21–30% (17.0%) and 1–5% (10.7%). These responses suggest that voters hold diverse preferences about audit scope, with a substantial share favoring comprehensive verification.

Figure A2: Preferred Share of Ballots Audited (Q17)

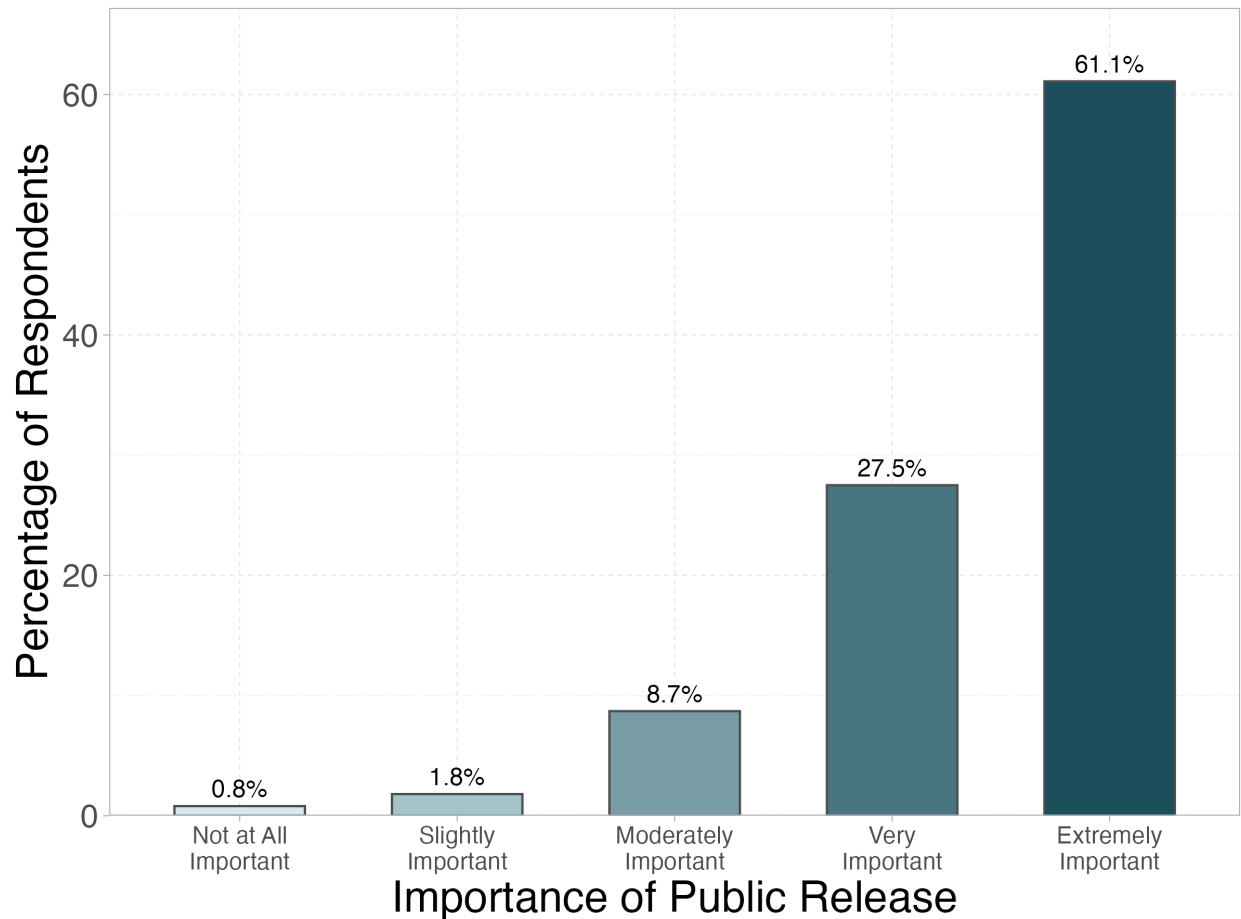


Note: Percentages shown above each bar. N = 2,030.

C.2 Importance of Public Release

Respondents were also asked how important it is that audit results be publicly released (Q18). Figure A3 presents the results. The overwhelming majority viewed public release as important: 61.1% rated it as “extremely important” and 27.5% as “very important,” for a combined 88.6%. Only 0.8% rated it as “not at all important.” These responses indicate strong public demand for audit transparency, consistent with the theoretical expectation that voters value the disclosure signal.

Figure A3: Importance of Public Release of Audit Results (Q18)

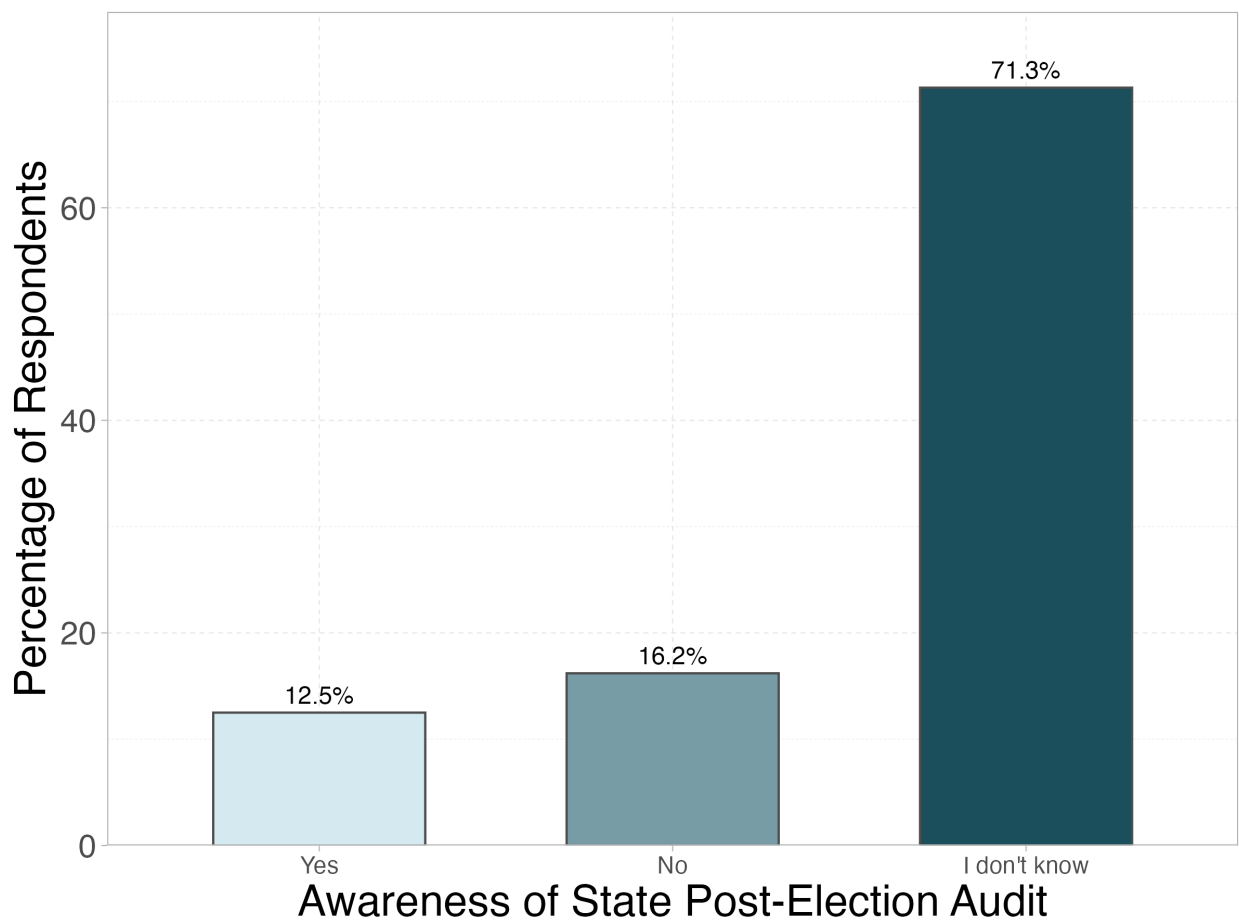


Note: Percentages shown above each bar. N = 2,030.

C.3 Audit Knowledge

Finally, respondents were asked whether they know if their state conducts a post-election audit (Q19). Figure A4 presents the results. Only 12.5% of respondents reported knowing that their state conducts an audit, while 71.3% said they did not know and 16.2% said no. Given that all 50 states now require some form of post-election audit ([Belant, 2026](#)), the low awareness rate underscores the disconnect between audit policy and public knowledge. This finding reinforces the argument that the mere existence of post-election audits is insufficient to build voter confidence; voters must also be made aware of both the process and its results.

Figure A4: Awareness of State Post-Election Audit (Q19)



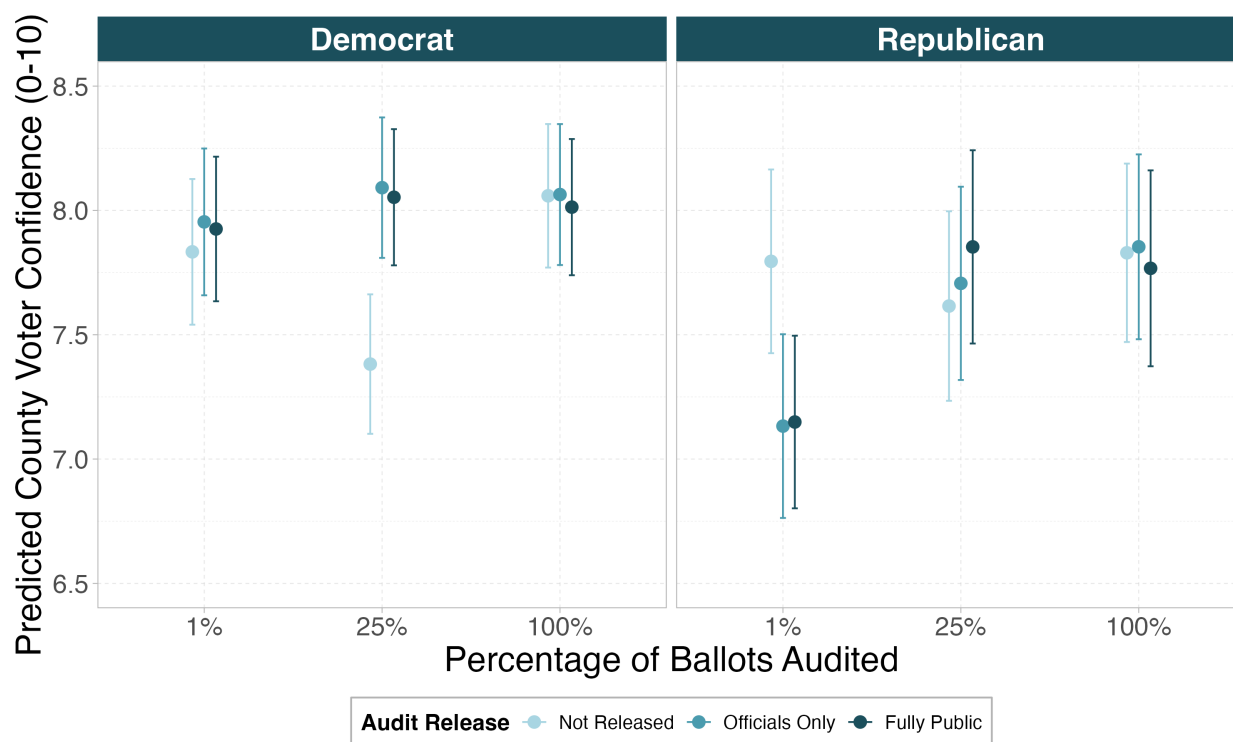
Note: Percentages shown above each bar. N = 2,030.

C.4 Heterogeneous Treatment Effects by Party

To examine whether treatment effects vary by partisanship, I estimated the treatment cell model interacted with party identification, comparing Democrats ($n = 1,261$) and Republicans ($n = 731$). Independent leaners were folded into the party they lean toward. Pure Independents ($n = 38$) were excluded from this analysis due to insufficient cell sizes for reliable estimation. Figure A5 presents predicted county-level voter confidence by treatment cell and party.

The most visible pattern is the baseline difference in confidence across parties: Democrats report substantially higher county-level confidence than Republicans across nearly all treatment conditions. Within each party, the general pattern from the main analysis is broadly visible. For Republicans, the 100% / fully public condition produces the highest predicted confidence, consistent with the full-sample finding. For Democrats, confidence is consistently high across conditions with less variation. These patterns are exploratory and the interaction model is not powered to detect significant differences across parties within individual treatment cells.

Figure A5: Treatment Effects on County-Level Voter Confidence by Party Identification



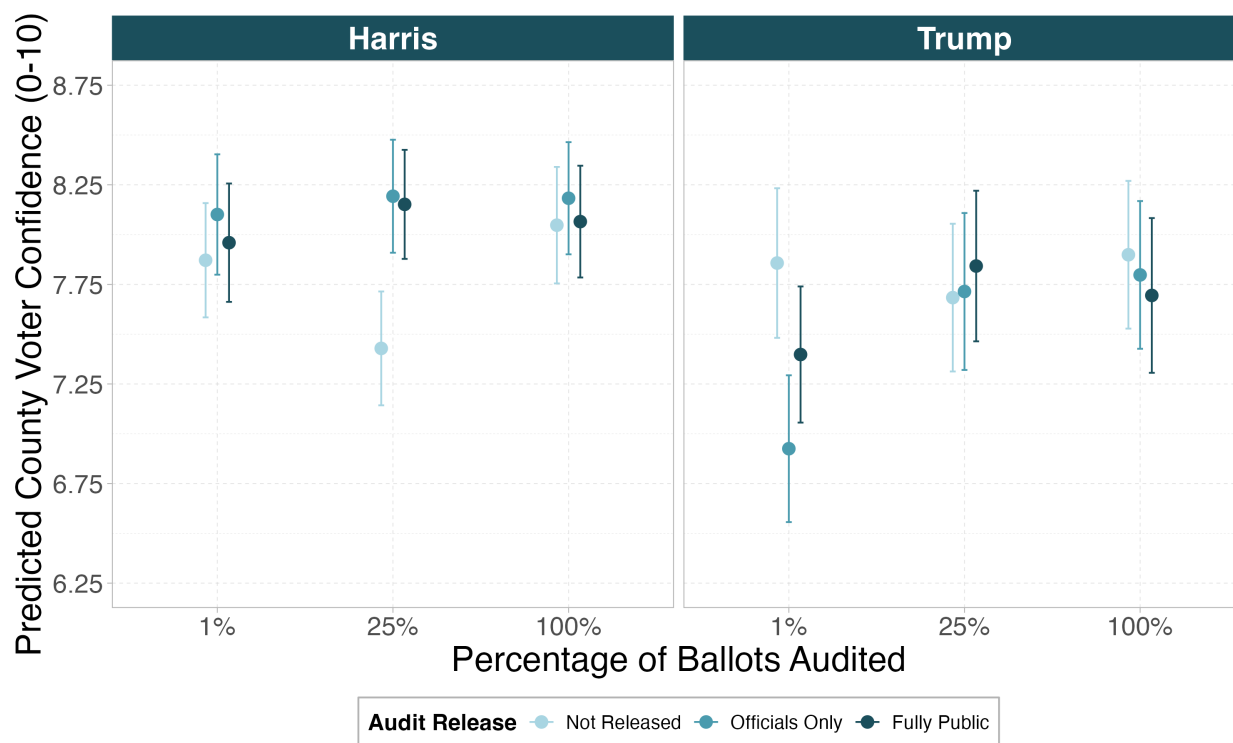
Note: Points represent predicted county-level voter confidence from OLS with treatment cell by party interaction, controlling for pre-treatment confidence. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Independent leaners folded into the party they lean toward. Pure Independents ($n = 38$) excluded. Democrat $n = 1,261$; Republican $n = 731$.

C.5 Heterogeneous Treatment Effects by Vote Choice

I also examined whether treatment effects vary by 2024 presidential vote choice, comparing Harris voters ($n = 1,189$) and Trump voters ($n = 705$). Respondents who voted for third-party candidates ($n = 136$) were excluded from this analysis. Figure A6 presents predicted county-level voter confidence by treatment cell and vote choice.

As with the party analysis, the most prominent feature is the baseline difference: Harris voters report higher county-level confidence than Trump voters across all treatment conditions. Within Trump voters, the treatment effects appear more pronounced, with greater variation across conditions and the 100% / fully public condition producing notably higher confidence. Within Harris voters, confidence is consistently high with less differentiation across treatment cells. This pattern is consistent with the winner-loser effect documented in the voter confidence literature (Craig et al., 2006; Sinclair, Smith, and Tucker, 2018; Hood and McKee, 2024): voters whose preferred candidate won the 2024 election enter with higher baseline confidence, leaving less room for the treatment to move their evaluations. These analyses are exploratory, and the interaction model is not powered to detect significant differences across vote choice within individual treatment cells.

Figure A6: Treatment Effects on County-Level Voter Confidence by 2024 Vote Choice



Note: Points represent predicted county-level voter confidence from OLS with treatment cell by vote choice interaction, controlling for pre-treatment confidence. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Harris $n = 1,189$; Trump $n = 705$. Respondents who voted for third-party candidates ($n = 136$) excluded.